



Annapurna  
College of Film and Media

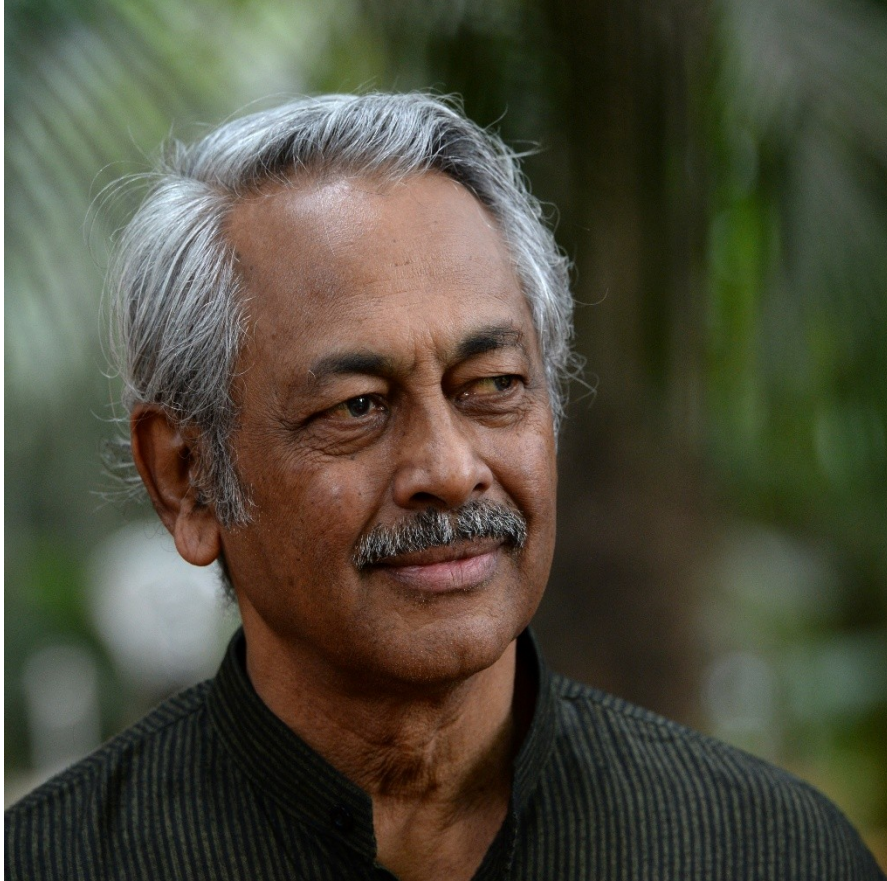
ANNAPURNA COLLEGE OF FILM AND MEDIA

*Department of Direction & Screenwriting*

# GIRISH KASARAVALLI

*The Quiet Master of Kannada Parallel Cinema*

*What a Direction Student Learns from Watching an Auteur at Work*



A Thesis submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the degree of  
**Master of Arts in Film Direction & Cinematography**

Submitted by

**R. S. Shashank Urs**

MA Film Direction & Cinematography

Under the guidance of

**Ms. Sakshi Gulati**

Direction & Screenwriting Department

Academic Year 2025 – 2026

## Declaration

---

I declare that this thesis, *Girish Kasaravalli: The Quiet Master of Kannada Parallel Cinema*, is my own work, written for my MA in Film Direction & Cinematography. The reading of the films is mine — the things I noticed, the questions I kept returning to, and the lessons I have tried to carry into my own practice as a director. Where I have relied on the writing, interviews, and scholarship of others, I have named them in the bibliography.

This is not meant to be the final word on Kasaravalli. It is a student's notebook, made public: an attempt to understand how one filmmaker built a body of work of such patience and moral seriousness, and to steal, respectfully, whatever I can use.

R. S. Shashank Urs  
MA2024016  
HL.No:24391SF017  
Hyderabad, 2026

## Abstract

---

Girish Kasaravalli is one of the few directors in India who spent an entire career refusing to make the film everyone wanted him to make. Over roughly five decades he built a run of work — fourteen National Film Awards, four of them for Best Feature Film — that treated cinema as a serious art, close to literature and closer still to the everyday life of Karnataka. This thesis is a study of how he did it, written from the point of view of a direction student trying to learn the craft.

I look at the man before the films: the boy from a Malnad village who grew up inside Yakshagana and reading, and who came to cinema through theatre rather than through fandom. I trace his years at the Film and Television Institute of India, where Ozu and the Italian neo-realists taught him to slow down and to trust the image. I then read his major films closely — *Ghatashraddha*, *Tabarana Kathe*, *Thaayi Saheba*, *Dweepa* — not as an award list but as a set of directorial decisions I can pull apart and understand.

A central chapter looks at Kasaravalli through his many faces: the reader, the theatre artist, the screenwriter and adapter, the director on set, and the teacher. The argument running underneath is simple. What makes him an auteur is not a signature camera move or a trademark shot. It is a consistent way of *looking* at people — patient, unhurried, unwilling to turn human beings into heroes or villains — that he carries from film to film. For a student, that is the real lesson, and the hardest one to copy.

# Table of Contents

|                                                                      |           |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| <b>Declaration.....</b>                                              | <b>2</b>  |
| <b>Abstract.....</b>                                                 | <b>3</b>  |
| <b>Chapter One — Why I Chose to Study Him.....</b>                   | <b>5</b>  |
| 1.1 What this thesis is trying to do.....                            | 5         |
| 1.2 Why he is worth a student's time.....                            | 5         |
| 1.3 How I went about it.....                                         | 6         |
| <b>Chapter Two — The Village That Made Him.....</b>                  | <b>7</b>  |
| 2.1 A house full of performance and print.....                       | 7         |
| 2.2 The uncle who opened a door: K. V. Subbanna.....                 | 8         |
| 2.3 The long way round to cinema.....                                | 9         |
| <b>Chapter Three — FTII, and Learning to See.....</b>                | <b>10</b> |
| 3.1 Ozu, and the courage to hold still.....                          | 10        |
| 3.2 Neo-realism: ordinary people, real places.....                   | 10        |
| 3.3 Early proof: Avashesh and Chomana Dudi.....                      | 11        |
| <b>Chapter Four — The Many Faces of Kasaravalli.....</b>             | <b>12</b> |
| 4.1 The reader.....                                                  | 12        |
| 4.2 The theatre artist.....                                          | 12        |
| 4.3 The writer and adapter.....                                      | 13        |
| 4.4 The director.....                                                | 13        |
| 4.5 The teacher.....                                                 | 13        |
| <b>Chapter Five — The Films: Close Readings.....</b>                 | <b>14</b> |
| 5.1 Ghatashraddha (1977).....                                        | 14        |
| 5.2 Tabarana Kathe (1986).....                                       | 15        |
| 5.3 Thaayi Saheba (1997).....                                        | 15        |
| 5.4 Dweepa (2002).....                                               | 15        |
| 5.5 The rest of a rich filmography.....                              | 16        |
| <b>Chapter Six — How He Directs: Style and Craft.....</b>            | <b>17</b> |
| <b>Chapter Seven — Turning Literature into Film.....</b>             | <b>18</b> |
| 7.1 The Ananthamurthy bond.....                                      | 18        |
| 7.2 The wider bookshelf.....                                         | 18        |
| 7.3 His idea of adaptation.....                                      | 18        |
| <b>Chapter Eight — Awards, Honours, and Standing.....</b>            | <b>19</b> |
| 8.1 A record of recognition.....                                     | 19        |
| 8.2 Standing at home and abroad.....                                 | 20        |
| <b>Chapter Nine — His Place in Parallel Cinema.....</b>              | <b>21</b> |
| 9.1 The movement he belonged to.....                                 | 21        |
| 9.2 The man who never crossed over.....                              | 21        |
| 9.3 What he leaves behind.....                                       | 21        |
| <b>Chapter Ten — The Silence at Home.....</b>                        | <b>22</b> |
| 10.1 Celebrated everywhere except home.....                          | 22        |
| 10.2 His own answer: the infrastructure.....                         | 22        |
| 10.3 The gap, named.....                                             | 23        |
| <b>Chapter Eleven — What I Take Away as a Direction Student.....</b> | <b>24</b> |
| <b>Bibliography.....</b>                                             | <b>25</b> |

## Why I Chose to Study Him

---

I did not grow up on Girish Kasaravalli. Like most people my age in Karnataka, the Kannada cinema of my childhood was the loud kind — bright colours, big fights, songs shot in Switzerland, a hero who could do anything. I loved it, and part of me still does. Kasaravalli came later, in film school, and at first I found his films slow. Nothing exploded. People sat in rooms and did not say much. The camera refused to move when I wanted it to move.

And then somewhere in the middle of *Ghatashraddha* I stopped waiting for something to happen and started watching what was actually there. A widow's face. A boy hiding in a courtyard. The heavy, unbroken quiet of a Brahmin village that has already decided a woman's fate. I realised the film was not slow at all. I had simply been trained to look at cinema in one way, and Kasaravalli was asking me to look in another. That shift — from watching *for* the plot to watching *at* the people — is the reason I wanted to write about him.

This thesis is written as a direction student, not as a critic sitting above the work. I am interested in the choices behind the frames. Why does he hold a shot that long? Why cast a woman who has never acted? Why take a famous novel and then quietly disobey it? These are not abstract questions for me. They are the questions I will have to answer on my own sets, and Kasaravalli is one of the clearest teachers I have found.

### 1.1 What this thesis is trying to do

I set myself a few honest aims:

- To understand the man who made the films — his village, his family, his theatre, his reading — because with Kasaravalli the life and the work are not separable.
- To read his major films at the level of craft: staging, camera, sound, performance, and cutting, in language a working director can use.
- To look at his “many faces” — reader, theatre artist, writer, director, teacher — and see how they feed one another.
- To place him inside the parallel cinema movement without letting the label flatten him into just another “art film” name.
- And, last, to be honest about what I can take from him and what I probably cannot, at least not yet.

### 1.2 Why he is worth a student's time

Kasaravalli is one of the most awarded directors India has produced, and yet outside festival halls and film schools most people have not seen a single film of his. That gap is itself interesting. He is proof that you can spend a career making exactly the films you believe in, refuse almost every commercial temptation, and still build something that lasts. For a young director staring at an industry that mostly rewards spectacle, that is not a small thing to witness.

There is also a Karnataka reason. He made his films in Kannada, from Kannada literature, about Karnataka's own villages and social knots — and he made them travel. Rotterdam held a retrospective of his work. Paris archived *Ghatashraddha*. He showed that the regional is not a smaller version of the national; done with enough honesty, the local becomes the widest thing of all. As someone who wants to keep working in Kannada, I need to believe that, and he lets me.

### 1.3 How I went about it

My main method is old and simple: watch the films, more than once, and pay attention. I have leaned on close viewing — stopping, going back, asking what a scene is doing and how. Around that I have read interviews, criticism, and the scholarship that exists, and where I could I have gone back to the Kannada literary sources his films grew out of. The frame I keep in mind is auteur theory: the idea that across many films a real director leaves a consistent way of seeing. My job was to name that way of seeing in Kasaravalli's case, in plain words, and then ask what a student is supposed to do with it.



## The Village That Made Him

---

You cannot understand Kasaravalli's films without understanding where he stood when he first looked at the world. He was born on 3 December 1950 in Kesalur, a small village in the Tirthahalli taluk of what was then Shimoga district. This is the Malnad — the rain country of Karnataka, thick with forest and areca plantations, wet for months, and full of stories that people tell out loud. The Malnad is not just a backdrop that turns up in his films. It is the ground his whole sensibility grew from: the greens, the greys of monsoon light, the slow rhythm of a place where the rain decides the day.



*The Malnad country of Karnataka, the physical and emotional landscape behind much of Kasaravalli's cinema.*

### 2.1 A house full of performance and print

His father, Ganesh Rao, was an agriculturist and a freedom fighter, and — this matters for us — a patron of Yakshagana. Yakshagana is the night-long folk theatre of coastal and Malnad Karnataka: painted faces, high costume, drums, sung narration, dialogue improvised on the spot. A child raised around Yakshagana absorbs a particular idea of storytelling long before he ever hears the word “mise-en-scène.” He learns that a face can be a mask and a truth at once, that music and speech carry a scene, that an audience will sit for hours if the performance earns it. Kasaravalli's patience with duration — his willingness to let a scene breathe — starts here, I think, in a field at night watching demons and kings argue until dawn.

The same house was full of books. His father put reading in front of him early, and it stuck. Long before FTII, Kasaravalli was a *reader* first — and that is the seed of everything he later did with literature on screen. His mother, Lakshmidēvi, kept the kind of joint-family home where these interests were allowed to matter. None of this was accidental. He grew up in a place that took culture seriously as a daily activity, not a luxury.

## 2.2 The uncle who opened a door: K. V. Subbanna

The most important person in his early education was not a filmmaker but his maternal uncle, K. V. Subbanna, the founder of Neenasam in Heggodu. Neenasam is one of the most respected cultural institutions in Karnataka — a theatre company and, later, a film society and a school, run out of a small town, that brought serious modern art to rural audiences. Subbanna later won the Ramon Magsaysay Award for exactly this: proving that world-class culture did not have to live in the big city.

Through Subbanna, the young Kasaravalli met modern theatre, experimental performance, and the idea that art could argue with society rather than just entertain it. But the deeper lesson Subbanna modelled was a way of being an artist: rooted in your own soil and open to the whole world at the same time. Local stories, cosmopolitan tools. That exact balance became the spine of Kasaravalli's career — Kannada novels shot with the rigour of Ozu. He got the template from his uncle before he ever picked up a camera.



*Neenasam, Heggodu — the cultural world, built by his uncle K. V. Subbanna, that shaped Kasaravalli long before film school.*



## 2.3 The long way round to cinema

His path to film was not straight, and that is oddly comforting to a student who worries about “starting late.” He studied in Kesalur and Kammaradi, then in Shimoga at Sahyadri College, where he sat under Kannada poets and writers and went deeper into the literature he already loved. Then, sensibly, he enrolled for a Bachelor of Pharmacy at Manipal. He was going to have a career.

It did not take. Through pharmacy college and then professional training in Hyderabad, theatre and cinema kept pulling at him until he could not do both honestly. At some point he made the decision that every artist from a modest background has to make against the wishes of common sense: he dropped the safe profession and went towards the uncertain one. He walked away from pharmacy and towards film. For a boy from a rural family, that was not a romantic gesture; it was a real risk. But he had already been formed — by Yakshagana, by books, by Subbanna — to believe that art was a life worth taking a risk for.

## FTII, and Learning to See

---

In the early 1970s Kasaravalli joined the Film and Television Institute of India in Pune — the school that had already sent out Ritwik Ghatak, Adoor Gopalakrishnan, and Kumar Shahani. If Kesalpur gave him his subject, FTII gave him his eyes. This is where a theatre-and-literature man learned the specific grammar of cinema, and, just as important, where he was shown what the medium was capable of at its highest level.

### 3.1 Ozu, and the courage to hold still

At FTII he watched the masters — Kurosawa, Ray, Fellini, Antonioni — but the one who marked him deepest was Yasujiro Ozu. Kasaravalli has said as much many times. It is easy to see why. Ozu built entire films out of families in rooms, a low camera that rarely moves, and enormous feeling held under a calm surface. He trusted stillness. He trusted the audience to lean in.

For a young director this is a genuinely radical thing to learn, because every instinct — and later every producer — pushes you to add movement, cuts, music, “energy.” Ozu gave Kasaravalli permission to do the opposite: to let a shot sit, to let a silence do the work, to believe that a still frame of an ordinary face can hold more than a dozen fancy angles. Almost everything I admire in Kasaravalli’s staging traces back to this decision to hold still on purpose.

“Kasaravalli has often named Ozu as his master — drawn to the Japanese director’s minimalism, his domestic spaces, and the way deep emotion is carried by restraint rather than display. — paraphrased from the director’s interviews”

### 3.2 Neo-realism: ordinary people, real places

The other great influence at this time was Italian neo-realism — De Sica, Rossellini — and the Indian parallel cinema that had grown out of it. Neo-realism’s lessons are practical and moral at once: shoot in real locations, use natural light, cast ordinary faces (sometimes non-actors), and point the camera at people the movies usually ignore. You can see all of this in Kasaravalli’s films: the actual villages, the daylight, the casting of unknowns and theatre people over stars.

It helped that he arrived when Indian parallel cinema was at full tide. Ray’s Apu films had already proved that a film could be both art and truthfully Indian. Sen, Benegal, Mani Kaul, Nihalani were all working. The air itself argued that cinema could be serious. Kasaravalli did not have to invent his conviction alone; he stepped into a movement that shared it. But he took from that movement only what suited him, and left the rest.

### 3.3 Early proof: Avashesh and Chomana Dudi

His talent showed while he was still a student. His diploma film, *Avashesh* (The Remains), won the President's Silver Lotus for Best Experimental Short and a National Film Award for Best Short Fiction — recognition before he had even graduated.

Just as valuable was the hands-on schooling he got as assistant director to B. V. Karanth on *Chomana Dudi* (1975), an adaptation of Shivarama Karanth's novel. Working under Karanth — himself a giant of Kannada theatre and cinema — Kasaravalli learned in practice what it takes to turn a piece of literature into a film, and what working inside Kannada cinema actually demands. He graduated from FTII in 1975 with a gold medal. What set him apart, though, was never only the medal. It was that he already knew what he wanted his films to *be*: rooted in Karnataka's real social life, and made to the highest standard of the art. Most of us leave film school still looking for that. He left with it.

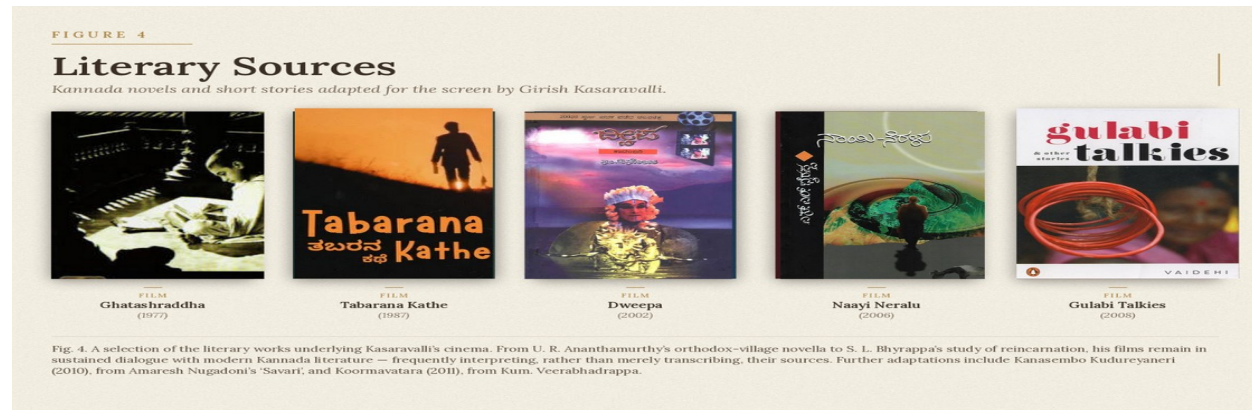
## The Many Faces of Kasaravalli

One thing became clear the more I studied him: Kasaravalli is not “just” a director. He is a reader, a theatre child, a writer, a director, and a teacher, and these are not separate hats he swaps between. They are the same person seen from different sides, and each face feeds the next. If you only study the director, you miss where the director came from. So this chapter looks at the man through his different faces — which is, I think, the most useful way for a student to understand him.

### 4.1 The reader

Before he was anything on a film set, Kasaravalli was a reader. He grew up inside Kannada literature and never really left it. Almost every important film he made began on a page — Ananthamurthy, Bhyrappa, Vaidehi, Norbert D’Souza, Amaresh Nudgoni, Kum. Veerabhadrappa. He is drawn especially to the *Navya* (modernist) writers who came up in the 1960s, whose work is psychologically sharp, socially critical, and formally restless. That is exactly the kind of material a filmmaker like him can build on.

What matters for us is that his reading is not decoration. It shapes how he thinks about character and structure. A director who reads seriously tends to distrust easy heroes and villains, because good fiction rarely allows them. You feel that literary intelligence in every film — in the refusal to simplify, in the patience with contradiction. The lesson is unglamorous but real: read, and read seriously, because what you read teaches you how to see people.



*A director who was first a reader: the Kannada literary works behind his major films.*

### 4.2 The theatre artist

The Yakshagana of his childhood and the modern theatre of Neenasam left permanent marks. From theatre he learned blocking before he learned coverage — how bodies arranged in a space create meaning, how an actor holds an audience, how a scene has an inner rhythm you can feel. Watch how he stages a room full of people in *Ghatashraddha* or *Thaayi Saheba*: the positions are not random. Someone is placed near the door, someone kept in shadow, someone left alone in the

centre of a frame. That is a theatre director's instinct for the stage picture, translated into the cinematic frame.

Theatre also gave him his way with actors, and his comfort casting non-actors and stage performers rather than stars. He was never chasing a face the audience already loved. He was chasing the *right* face for the person. That is a theatre value — truth of character over glamour — and it runs through his whole cast list.

### 4.3 The writer and adapter

Kasaravalli wrote or co-wrote the screenplays of his films, and here is the interesting part: he did not treat the novels he loved as sacred. He read them as a filmmaker, which means he was willing to disobey them. He has said plainly that a director's job is not to illustrate a book but to engage with it — to add his own reading, to make choices that serve cinema even when they depart from the page. He called *Naayi Neralu* an interpretation of Bhyrappa's novel, not a faithful copy, and shifted its emphasis toward the themes that interested *him*.

This has earned him some criticism in Karnataka's literary circles, where people who love a novel do not always love what a film does to it. But as a screenwriting stance it is exactly right. Literature and cinema are different instruments. What sings on the page can die on screen, and the adapter's courage is precisely the willingness to change it. For a writer-director this is the whole game: honour the spirit, rewrite the letter.

### 4.4 The director

All of the above meets on set, in the director. And what defines him there is control without noise. He is a formalist — every element of the frame is chosen — but he hides the effort. Nothing shows off. The camera does not announce itself. The cutting does not hurry you. He composes, lights, blocks, and paces with great precision, and then makes it all look like life simply unfolding. That invisibility of technique is the hardest thing in direction, and the surest sign of a master. Chapter Six takes his directing apart in detail; here I only want to name it as one face among several.

### 4.5 The teacher

Kasaravalli also served as the head of a film institute in Bengaluru and has mentored younger filmmakers for years. This face is easy to overlook and important not to. A director who teaches has to make his instincts speakable — he has to turn “I just felt it should be there” into something a student can actually learn. His willingness to teach, and to keep defending an uncommercial idea of cinema to the next generation, is part of why his influence outlives any single film. As a student on the receiving end of that tradition, I feel the debt directly.

*For Kasaravalli, cinema was never only about telling a story. It was a way of examining the human condition in all its contradiction — which is why his films ask to be reflected on rather than merely watched.* — a recurring idea in his interviews

## The Films — Close Readings

This chapter reads his major films the way I was taught to read a scene: not “what happens” but “how is it made, and why that way.” I keep to the four Best Feature Film winners in detail, then move faster through the rest of a remarkable filmography.

### 5.1 Ghatashraddha (1977) — the debut that arrived fully formed

His first feature, *Ghatashraddha* (The Ritual), is one of the great debuts in Indian cinema, and the astonishing thing is how little it feels like a first film. Adapted from a novella by U. R. Ananthamurthy, it is set in an orthodox Brahmin *agrahara* in the 1920s. Yamunakka, a young widow, becomes pregnant after an affair with the village schoolmaster. When it is discovered, her own father performs the *ghatashraddha* — a ritual of excommunication that declares her, in effect, socially dead. We watch much of it through Nani, a small boy who is bullied at school and finds shelter in Yamunakka’s kindness.

What a student should study here is the *point of view*. By filtering a woman’s destruction through a child’s confused eyes, Kasaravalli avoids both melodrama and sermon. The boy does not fully understand what is happening, so neither, quite, do we — and that partial understanding is far more disturbing than any speech about injustice would be. The film shows the machinery of cruelty at work without ever raising its voice.

The look supports this completely. It is shot in stark black and white, the exteriors slightly overexposed, so the village feels bleached, exposed, without a place to hide. The camera mostly observes. Kasaravalli cast Meena Kuttappa, then still his student, as Yamunakka, and her performance moves from tenderness to desire to a terrible resignation without a single false note. The film refuses to sentimentalise her and refuses to preach at us. It just looks, steadily, and lets the looking become an argument.



*Ghatashraddha* (1977) — the debut feature. Golden Lotus for Best Feature Film at the 25th National Film Awards; later selected among the great films of Indian cinema.



## 5.2 Tabarana Kathe (1986) — the dignity of a small man

Nearly a decade on, *Tabarana Kathe* (Tabara's Story) confirmed that *Ghatashraddha* was no accident. Where the debut sat in the 1920s, this one is closer to the present, and where the debut watched a woman, this one follows an old retired peon, Tabara, ground down by an indifferent bureaucracy as he tries simply to get what he is owed. The film watches a man lose everything to paperwork, procedure, and neglect, and it treats that small, unspectacular tragedy with the seriousness usually reserved for kings.

The directorial lesson is about scale and attention. Kasaravalli takes a figure the movies would normally use for comic relief — a poor old government servant — and gives him a full inner life and a genuine tragic weight. The critique of institutions here is not shouted; it is shown through accumulation, one small humiliation after another, until the total is unbearable. It won him his second Golden Lotus for Best Feature Film.

## 5.3 Thaayi Saheba (1997) — his most complex construction

By *Thaayi Saheba*, Kasaravalli is working at the height of his powers, and the film is often called his most mature. Through the story of a family and its matriarch, it tracks India's passage from before Independence to after — and asks a hard question: did freedom actually change the daily lives of ordinary people, especially women, or only the flags above them?

For a student, the thing to study here is *structure*. The film moves across time and viewpoint in a layered way that is genuinely ambitious — this is a director confident enough to break linear storytelling and trust the audience to hold several time frames at once. The formal control matches the thematic weight. Framing, cutting, sound, performance are all locked together. It is the kind of film that opens up more on a second and third viewing, which is its own kind of compliment to the viewer. It earned his third Golden Lotus.

## 5.4 Dweepa (2002) — opening the frame

*Dweepa* (The Island) is where his style visibly widens. Based on a novel by Norbert D'Souza, it follows a family on an island who face being drowned out when a dam is built — development arriving as a flood. After years of spare black-and-white minimalism, here Kasaravalli embraces colour, music, and the lush monsoon landscape of Karnataka. The film is more expansive, more openly beautiful, without losing its moral spine.

At its centre is the late Soundarya, giving a powerful performance as a woman caught between her ancestral land and the promise of "progress." The film asks who actually pays for development, and answers honestly: the poor, the rooted, the ones without a voice in the plan. *Dweepa* won his fourth Golden Lotus and, unusually for parallel cinema, found a real audience — proof that his more accessible later manner could reach people without softening what it had to say.



*Dweepa (2002) — the later, more expansive Kasaravalli. Fourth Golden Lotus for Best Feature Film.*

## 5.5 The rest of a rich filmography

Around these four sit many more films that reward attention:

- *Akramana* (1979) and *Mooru Darigalu* (1981) continued his study of social hierarchy and institutional power.
- *Bannada Vesha* (1988) looked at tradition and change in rural Karnataka.
- *Mane / Ek Ghar* (1990), his first city film and first bilingual work, cast Naseeruddin Shah, Deepti Naval, and Rohini Hattangadi, and turned to urban loneliness and the cracking of the old family.
- *Kraurya* (1996) treated loneliness with an unexpected touch of humour — a wider tonal range than people credit him with.
- *Hasina* (2004) experimented with melodrama and centred a Muslim woman's life; it won Best Film on Social Concern nationally.
- *Naayi Neralu* (2006), from Bhyrappa, took on reincarnation and belief, and became the first Kannada film to win top honours at an international festival (KARA, Karachi).
- *Gulabi Talkies* (2008), from a Vaidehi story, showed how far-off political events seep into a small life; it won at several festivals and the State Award for Best Film.
- *Kanasemba Kudureyaneri* (2010), from Amaresh Nudgoni, used a non-linear structure to explore family bonds, and travelled widely.
- *Koormavatara* (2011), from Kum. Veerabhadrappe, follows a retired clerk who resembles Gandhi and is cast to play him on TV — a quietly meta reflection on image, memory, and media. It won the National Award for Best Kannada Film.

## How He Directs — Style and Craft

---

This is the chapter I most wanted to write, because it is the one I can actually use. Below I try to name, in working terms, the directorial habits that make a Kasaravalli film recognisably his.

### *The still, patient camera*

His camera mostly stays put, or moves so gently you barely notice. He builds meaning through composition and blocking rather than through movement and cutting. The long take is one of his key tools: hold the shot, let the scene play, let time itself become part of the emotion. This forces you to *watch* rather than be dragged along. For a student raised on fast coverage, the discipline of asking “does this shot really need to move, or cut?” is one of the most valuable things he teaches.

### *Mise-en-scène carrying the story*

Everything inside the frame is doing work — where a person stands, what light falls on them, what is left in shadow, how the space is arranged. He composes so that the picture already tells you the relationships and the tensions before anyone speaks. This is the theatre director in him, thinking in stage pictures, translated into the film frame.

### *Silence and sound as instruments*

Mainstream cinema fears silence and fills every gap with dialogue or score. Kasaravalli treats silence as material. He lets quiet stretches sit, charged and full, so that small sounds — a footstep, wind, distant work — land with weight. He is confident enough to give the audience nothing to listen to but the scene itself. Restraint, again, as a source of power.

### *Women at the centre*

His films put women at the centre far more than the mainstream ever did, and not as decoration or as passive sufferers. From Yamunakka to the woman of *Dweepa*, they carry responsibility, make hard choices, and push back against the limits placed on them. He understood gender as one of the main axes of power in Indian life, and built his stories on it. That is a worldview, not a genre.

### *Character as system, not as saint or sinner*

Maybe his deepest habit: he refuses easy heroes and villains. His characters are people caught inside systems — caste, ritual, bureaucracy, family — that are larger than any one of them, and even the ones with power are trapped by the structures they enforce. This keeps his films from turning into simple morality tales. It is also the hardest thing to imitate, because it is not a technique. It is a way of seeing human beings, and you cannot fake it.

### *Rooted place, universal reach*

Finally, the specificity. He never smooths Karnataka into a generic “Indian village.” The exact rituals, the exact landscape, the exact social knots of the Malnad are all there in detail — and it is *because* of that detail, not despite it, that the films speak to anyone anywhere. The particular, looked at honestly enough, becomes universal. For a director who wants to work in his own language and place, this is the most liberating lesson of all.

## Turning Literature into Film

---

Kasaravalli's bond with Kannada literature is so central that it deserves its own chapter. From his very first film he mined the region's writing for stories, and in doing so he strengthened the whole link between Kannada literature and Kannada cinema.

### 7.1 The Ananthamurthy bond

U. R. Ananthamurthy matters most. The two came from almost the same soil — Ananthamurthy from Melige, Kasaravalli from Kesalur, about twenty kilometres apart — and that shared Malnad world gave their collaboration a natural depth. *Ghatashraddha* came from Ananthamurthy's novella, and it set the pattern for how Kasaravalli would adapt: take real creative liberties, add his own reading, but keep faith with the spirit and the moral seriousness of the source.

Their relationship went past work into friendship and a kind of intellectual partnership — one man working in words, the other in images, both examining the same society. In 2015 Kasaravalli made a documentary, *Ananthamurthy... Not a Biography... But a Hypothesis*, mixing interview and archive to trace the writer's mind. It reads almost like a debt being repaid.

### 7.2 The wider bookshelf

Beyond Ananthamurthy he drew on many writers — S. L. Bhyrappa (*Naayi Neralu*), Vaidehi (*Gulabi Talkies*), Amaresh Nudgoni (*Kanasemba Kudureyaneri*), Norbert D'Souza (*Dweepa*), Kum. Veerabhadrappe (*Koormavataara*). Each film brought a fine piece of Kannada writing to new audiences, and each was reshaped by the same firm directorial hand.

### 7.3 His idea of adaptation

His adaptation philosophy, as I said earlier, is not to serve the book but to converse with it. He does not see the filmmaker as an illustrator. He writes the screenplay as a fresh act of authorship, adding his own insights, sometimes departing sharply from the plot — as he did with *Naayi Neralu*, which he openly called an interpretation. Some readers resent this. I think it is the only honest way to adapt. A film that merely photographs a novel betrays both. What Kasaravalli makes are genuinely new works that carry the old one inside them.

## Awards, Honours, and Standing

I have kept the awards for their own chapter deliberately, because a list of prizes is the least interesting true thing about him — and yet the sheer weight of recognition is part of the story. 14 National Film Awards place him among the most honoured directors India has produced.

### 8.1 A record of recognition

| Film / Work                    | Year | Award                                       |
|--------------------------------|------|---------------------------------------------|
| <i>Avashesh</i> (diploma film) | 1975 | National Award, Best Short Fiction Film     |
| <i>Ghatashraddha</i>           | 1977 | Golden Lotus, Best Feature Film             |
| <i>Tabarana Kathe</i>          | 1986 | Golden Lotus, Best Feature Film             |
| <i>Thaayi Saheba</i>           | 1997 | Golden Lotus, Best Feature Film             |
| <i>Dweepa</i>                  | 2002 | Golden Lotus, Best Feature Film             |
| <i>Hasina</i>                  | 2004 | National Award, Best Film on Social Concern |
| <i>Koormavatara</i>            | 2011 | National Award, Best Kannada Film           |
| Padma Shri                     | 2011 | Government of India (civilian honour)       |
| Jaffna Int'l Cinema Festival   | 2024 | Lifetime Achievement Award                  |

*A selected record of major honours (not exhaustive — he also holds numerous Karnataka State Film Awards).*



*Kasaravalli among India's most honoured filmmakers.*

## 8.2 Standing at home and abroad

At the state level his shelf is just as full — Best Director and Best Film for *Naayi Neralu*, Best Film for *Gulabi Talkies*, and more. Internationally, Rotterdam gave him a full retrospective in 2003, a rare honour that set him beside major world directors. *Ghatashraddha* was archived in Paris and named among the finest films in Indian history at IFFI 2009. *Naayi Neralu* won at Karachi; *Koormavatara* screened at seventeen festivals and drew praise from Bangkok to New York to Vancouver. In 2011 the nation gave him the Padma Shri, and in 2024 Jaffna honoured his lifetime of work. Festivals and institutions have held retrospectives in his name — the kind of thing usually reserved for filmmakers whose work has become a permanent part of the canon.



## His Place in Parallel Cinema, and What He Leaves Behind

---

To see him whole, you have to place him inside the parallel cinema movement — and then notice how he refused to follow even that movement's later drift.

### 9.1 The movement he belonged to

Parallel cinema rose in India through the 1960s and 70s as the serious alternative to commercial film — realist, socially engaged, formally adventurous, and helped along by state funding. Ray's Apu films were its foundation; Sen, Benegal, Mani Kaul, Shahani, Nihalani carried it forward in the north. In the south it produced Adoor Gopalakrishnan and Aravindan in Malayalam, and B. V. Karanth in Kannada. Kasaravalli became the movement's central Kannada voice: rejecting formula, casting theatre and non-actors, shooting real locations, and holding to serious themes.

### 9.2 The man who never crossed over

Here is what sets him apart. As state funding dried up, many of his peers drifted toward more commercial work to survive. Kasaravalli did not. He is very likely the one major Kannada filmmaker who never made the crossing from parallel to commercial cinema — he simply kept making the films he believed in, and paid the price in money and audience size. For a student weighing how much to compromise, that steadfastness is both inspiring and sobering. It cost him. He chose it anyway.

### 9.3 What he leaves behind

His legacy runs in a few directions. He proved Kannada cinema could reach the world without leaving home. He deepened the bond between the region's literature and its cinema, opening a path for writers and for the idea that adaptation is real filmmaking. Through teaching he shaped younger directors. And his films quietly preserve a Karnataka — its rituals, its landscapes, its ways of living — that is fading, so that his work now doubles as a record of a world.

You can feel his influence, indirectly, in later Indian directors who fold realism and social conscience into more commercial frames. The values he stood for — integrity, patience, respect for one's own culture, faith in the audience's intelligence — keep mattering to anyone who wants to make cinema that means something.

## The Silence at Home

---

I have to write about something that troubled me through this whole project, because leaving it out would make the thesis dishonest. Somewhere in my research I noticed a strange thing. Almost everything serious ever written about Girish Kasaravalli — the director I chose precisely because he is *ours*, a Kannada filmmaker working from Kannada soil and Kannada literature — I was reading in English, and mostly written by people from outside Karnataka. I am a Kannadiga trying to understand a Kannada master, and to do it I kept having to lean on outsiders.

Look at my own bibliography and you will see it plainly. The interviews and essays I depended on came from *The Federal*, *The News Minute*, *India Art Review*, *MAP India* — national English outlets. The one book-length study I could find, Sakti Sengupta's account of his films, is in English, by someone from outside the Kannada world. I went looking for the Kannada book, the long Kannada monograph, the deep Kannada academic essay that a director of his standing should have produced at home. I did not find much. By the end, that absence stopped feeling like a gap in my reading and started feeling like part of my subject.

### 10.1 Celebrated everywhere except home

What makes it sting more is how celebrated he is everywhere else. Critics have long observed — and he has said versions of it himself in interviews — that his films receive deeper retrospectives, stronger film-society support, and more academic attention from Bengal, Maharashtra, Kerala, and international festivals than from the mainstream audience in his own state. In West Bengal especially he is spoken of almost as an heir to the line of Ray, Ghatak, and Mrinal Sen. His work opens new-cinema sections at festivals far from Karnataka. The applause he could not always find at home came to him from outside it.

It was, in fact, the film-society movement — largely the one outside Karnataka — that first carried him. When *Ghatashraddha* appeared in 1977, societies across India screened it, and that is how viewers in Kerala, Maharashtra, and elsewhere came to know his name at all. The path his early work travelled ran outward from Karnataka before it ever ran inward.

### 10.2 His own answer: it is the infrastructure, not the audience

To his credit, Kasaravalli has never turned this into contempt for the Kannada viewer. In interviews he has argued that the real obstacle is not that audiences here reject serious cinema, but that the exhibition and distribution machinery is built only for mainstream films — there is simply nowhere for a small, socially-serious film to be seen. In Europe and America, he has pointed out, there are avenues made for exactly this kind of cinema; we never built them. It is a structural failure, not a failure of appetite. I find that a generous and probably correct diagnosis, and it does not make the silence any less real.

Even his response to honours carries the same quality. When he received the Padma Shri in 2011, he framed it not as a personal prize but as a recognition for Kannada cinema as a whole. It is a

gracious instinct — and, if you sit with it, a quietly sad one: the man keeps turning the light back onto a film culture that has not fully turned its own light onto him.

### 10.3 The gap, named

His family has lived inside this contradiction too. The household carried the cost of a life given to art cinema that does not pay, balanced against more commercial work taken up to sustain a career, and his children have continued in film. I want to be careful here, because I could not find a clear Kannada statement from the family openly protesting the neglect — and that carefulness is itself part of the point. The sharpest laments, about how a director with fourteen National Awards can struggle to secure even a week's local screening, tend to come from critics and journalists writing *on his behalf*, not from a settled body of Kannada scholarship. Even the complaint about the silence is mostly voiced in someone else's language.

So this is the gap I kept circling. A filmmaker whose entire art grows out of Kannada language, Kannada writing, and Kannada village life, and who is nonetheless under-served by Kannada film scholarship itself. I do not think it is malice. It is infrastructure, market, and a slow habit of neglect toward our own art cinema. But as a student from Karnataka, it is a hard thing to sit with — that the fullest accounts of arguably our greatest director are written in a language he chose not to make his films in.

I cannot repair that with one student thesis, and I am not pretending to. But somewhere in the frustration I understood better why I was drawn to write this at all. This is, in its small way, an attempt to look at him closely in a student's own voice, from inside the state that produced him, and to begin — even if only for myself — the appreciation I kept searching for and could not find. That is where this leads me, and it is where the final chapter begins.

---

*A note on sources for this chapter: the positions summarised above are drawn from the director's interviews and from critical commentary written about him. Where I have paraphrased his own arguments — on exhibition infrastructure, and on the film-society movement carrying his early work — the exact interview citations should be inserted here once verified against the original recordings or transcripts. His framing of the Padma Shri as a recognition for Kannada cinema is reported in Deccan Herald (25 January 2011). I have deliberately not placed his remarks inside quotation marks, since I could not confirm the precise wording; they are given as his known positions, not as verbatim quotation.*

---

## What I Take Away as a Direction Student

---

I want to end not with a summary but with an honest account of what I am carrying away, because that was the point of studying him in the first place.

The first thing is patience. Kasaravalli taught me that holding a shot, trusting a silence, and letting a scene find its own time is not “slow” — it is a choice, and often the braver one. My instinct, and the instinct the industry trains into you, is to add: more cuts, more music, more movement. He does the opposite, and his films are stronger for the subtraction. I want to learn when to leave the camera alone.

The second is how to see people. His refusal of heroes and villains, his patience with contradiction, his insistence that even the person doing harm is trapped in something larger — that is not a camera trick. It comes from reading seriously and from looking at real people without flinching. This is the lesson I know I cannot copy quickly. It has to be grown.

The third is the courage of the local. He never apologised for being a Kannada filmmaker telling Karnataka’s stories, and the world came to him anyway. As someone who wants to build a career in Kannada cinema and Kannada storytelling, I need that example in front of me — proof that you do not have to leave your own soil to make something that travels. If anything, the soil is the source of the reach.

And the fourth is harder to name. It is his stubbornness — the way he decided what kind of films he would make and then made them for fifty years without blinking, even when it cost him money and audiences. I do not know yet whether I will have that much spine. Very few do. But now I have watched someone who did, closely enough to know it is possible.

So this thesis ends where it started, in a dark room, a little bored, waiting for something to explode — and then slowly learning to watch. If Kasaravalli teaches one thing above all, it is that. Learn to watch. The rest of direction follows from there.

## REFERENCES

### Bibliography

---

#### **Primary sources — films directed by Girish Kasaravalli**

*Ghatashraddha* (The Ritual), 1977

*Akramana*, 1979

*Mooru Darigalu*, 1981

*Tabarana Kathe* (Tabara's Story), 1986

*Bannada Vessa*, 1988

*Mane / Ek Ghar* (The House), 1990

*Kraurya*, 1996

*Thaayi Saheba*, 1997

*Dweepa* (The Island), 2002

*Hasina*, 2004

*Naayi Neralu* (In the Shadow of the Dog), 2006

*Gulabi Talkies*, 2008

*Kanasemba Kudureyaneri* (Riding the Stallion of a Dream), 2010

*Koormavatara* (The Tortoise, An Incarnation), 2011

*Illiralare Allige Hogalare*, 2020

#### **Secondary sources**

Sengupta, Sakti. *Discovering Indian Independent Cinema: The Films of Girish Kasaravalli*, 2015.

Pal, Shorna. "Review: Discovering Indian Independent Cinema." *Frames Cinema Journal*, 6 December 2015.

"It's Recognition to Kannada Cinema: Girish." *Deccan Herald*, 25 January 2011.

"The Films of Girish Kasaravalli." *The Seventh Art*, 13 March 2011.

"Girish Kasaravalli: A Legend of Parallel Cinema." *Wogma*.

"The Parallel Cinema of Girish Kasaravalli." *The News Minute*, 17 August 2023.

"From Literature to Lens with Girish Kasaravalli." *India Art Review*, 22 January 2024.

"Girish Kasaravalli Interview." *The Federal*, 24 March 2024.

"Girish Kasaravalli Returns to U. R. Ananthamurthy's World." *The Federal*, 29 September 2024.

"Film Review: Ghatashraddha (1977)." *Asian Movie Pulse*, 13 October 2024.

"Art in Motion: Girish Kasaravalli on the Centrality of Women in his Cinema." *MAP India*, 4 August 2025.

Wikipedia contributors. "Girish Kasaravalli." *Wikipedia*.

*A note on images: the photographs and film stills reproduced in this thesis are included for academic and non-commercial study only. They remain the property of their respective owners and sources, to whom they are credited where applicable.*

## Figure Credits

Fig. 1. Girish Kasaravalli. Source: Imagine India Film Festival ([imagineindiafestival.com](http://imagineindiafestival.com)).

Fig. 2. The Malnad landscape. Source: to be confirmed by the author.

Fig. 3. Neenasam, Heggodu, and K. V. Subbanna. Sources: Careerindia ([careerindia.com](http://careerindia.com)); Karnataka.com.

Fig. 4. The literary works behind Kasaravalli's films. Composite created by the author using Canva, from web-sourced cover images. Source images:

- Dweepa cover — Harivu Books: <https://harivubooks.com/cdn/shop/files/Dweepa.png?v=1777551950&width=713>
- Cover via Amazon: <https://m.media-amazon.com/images/I/41FtfHh+PCL.jpg>
- Cover via TMDB (The Movie Database):  
[https://media.themoviedb.org/t/p/w220\\_and\\_h330\\_face/kkwHkvBbgXo4b60TMoaA7sOowwv.jpg](https://media.themoviedb.org/t/p/w220_and_h330_face/kkwHkvBbgXo4b60TMoaA7sOowwv.jpg)
- Cover image (Google image-cache link): [https://encrypted-tbn1.gstatic.com/shopping?q=tbn:ANd9GcSAMsT9BMv\\_EL6Kr20i6LEerowfTVTi2tjBI\\_yPRY78CfQrh9kN-EzMzmzDEKsQzj\\_VmBpWp361ScwKTK5jnirCCXbFl-apRuWOUhq2UECJ](https://encrypted-tbn1.gstatic.com/shopping?q=tbn:ANd9GcSAMsT9BMv_EL6Kr20i6LEerowfTVTi2tjBI_yPRY78CfQrh9kN-EzMzmzDEKsQzj_VmBpWp361ScwKTK5jnirCCXbFl-apRuWOUhq2UECJ)
- Cover image (Google image-cache link): <https://encrypted-tbn0.gstatic.com/images?q=tbn:ANd9GcS89AyoOO44u4NXiScIgznuUEezUJgOmA5KWdH0m55yKgNZewtgUKQZDhJAWPiCA>

*Covers remain the property of their respective publishers, reproduced for academic and non-commercial study only.*

Fig. 5. Ghatashraddha (1977) — poster and restored still. Sources: Wikipedia ([upload.wikimedia.org](http://upload.wikimedia.org)); Reddit ([reddit.com](http://reddit.com)).

Fig. 6. Dweepa (2002) — poster and still. Sources: Wikipedia ([upload.wikimedia.org](http://upload.wikimedia.org)); SunNXT ([sunnxt.com](http://sunnxt.com)).

Fig. 7. Kasaravalli receiving national honours. Sources: The Times of India ([toi.com](http://toi.com)); Prajavani ([prajavani.net](http://prajavani.net)).

*All images above are reproduced for academic and non-commercial study only and remain the property of their respective owners and sources.*